Dataset Facts

Dataset National Longitudinal Survey of Youth 1997 (NLSY97)
Unit of Observation One respondent, with variables from multiple survey years
Dataset Size 8,984 respondents; 12 variables in expanded extract

Motivation

Original Authors U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)
Original Use Case Study youth transitions from school to work, including education, employment, and family experiences
Funding U.S. Department of Labor, through the BLS

Composition

Sample or Complete Longitudinal sample of 8,984 youth born 1980–1984; includes cross-sectional and oversample respondents
Missing Data Includes refusals (-1), don't knows (-2), invalid skips (-3), valid skips (-4), and non-interviews (-5)
Sensitive Information Household income, parental education, race/ethnicity, and adult earnings; income values are topcoded

Collection Process

Sampling Strategy Probability-based sample with cross-sectional and Black/Hispanic oversamples
Collection Period Study began in 1997; this extract uses 1997 background data and 2020 employment outcomes
Ethical Review Specific IRB approval not documented in the reviewed extract codebook
Consent Consent procedures not documented in the reviewed extract codebook

Preprocessing

Cleaning Done Editing timeline of information to ensure consistency
Labeling Done Variable labels and standardized missing-value codes provided in the NLSY97 codebook

Uses and Distribution

Notable Uses Tracking employment, family dynamics, health/well-being, crime and substance abuse
Raw Data Available Yes, raw data is accessible but is distributed based on data sensitivity
Format and Terms CSV extract from NLSY97 public-use data; subject to BLS data-use guidance
Redistribution Public-use data are in the public domain and carry no restrictive commercial licensing fees or copyright barriers

Maintenance

Updates Interviews conducted every 2 years since 2013 and data is actively updated
Maintainers U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) sponsors and maintains the NLSY97 Survey of Youth

Limitations: Findings cannot be automatically generalized to older or younger generations
Sources: BLS NLSY97 Overview; NLSY97 Documentation; NLSY97 Expanded Extract Codebook

Figure 1: A data card styled after nutrition labels. Created for the retrospective BookCorpus datasheet, with help from Stack Exchange. See Gebru et al. for guidance on creating complete datasheets for datasets.